

Episode 23: Bishops, Papal Bulls, and the Problem of Domination

[Peter] (0:03 - 0:53)

Good morning, Steve.

[Steve] Good morning, Peter. How are you?

[Peter] Doing very well. Yourself?

[Steve] I'm okay.

[Peter] Good. So, today I'm going to start off by kind of interviewing you. You've just been up at a big multi-day meeting involving some kind of Catholic organization in Canada, I think.

I mean, I know it was in Canada, but I don't really know the organization. I just know you were involved in discussions around all these issues, the long history of interventions in this continent from the other continent. At least that's how I'm gathering what they build it as.

So, maybe why don't you just say where have you been recently and I'll ask more questions when they occur to me.

[Steve] (0:54 - 5:53)

Sure. Well, thanks for asking. I was up in Edmonton, Alberta, which is the Cree Nation Treaty 6 territory, and it was a convening sponsored by the Catholic Conference of Bishops in Canada and also attended by the Catholic Conference of Bishops in the United States, at least representation from those two organizations.

And there were a number of indigenous peoples representatives and the scholars into the Doctrine of Discovery. It was framed as a knowledge-sharing symposium on the Doctrine of Discovery. And there was a tremendous amount of expertise.

There were two wonderful gentlemen who are traditional storytellers, Stephen George from the Anishinaabe Nation, and John Day, who's from the Dene Nation, way up in Yellowknife, that area. And there were a number of people. I was specifically invited by Willie Littlechild, who's from the Cree Nation, and also Archbishop Don Bolan, who is the Archbishop in Saskatchewan.

Oh, maybe it's Regina. I'm not certain. But in any case, but there was also representation from the Department of Integral Human Development from the Vatican.

Cardinal Czerny could not attend because he had to be in Rome for the release of the encyclical by Pope Leo XIV, I believe it is, and he couldn't attend, but he had a point person come to the event. And so there was representation. I think there were two different areas of the Vatican.

In any case, the main point was to have a very candid discussion of the so-called Doctrine of Discovery, which I, some people don't like me to use that so-called term,

but the only reason I say that is because of the theme that I believe is most important that we talk all about, the theme of domination. And that's really, to me, the problem that we're dealing with is the claim of a right of domination. Obviously, we've discussed that endlessly.

And there were just an array of different scholars who have deep grounding in the material. And so I think that the, when all was said and done after three intensive days, beginning around nine in the morning, with significant break time, two times in the day, meal times and such, we went about 10 hours a day. And it was quite extraordinary, I think.

I think everyone came away from it with a sense of, oh, excitement, maybe even, and the commitment to continue dialogue and discussion going forward. Now, what that means, who knows? But I think that one of the things that I did say during my presentation on the opening day, in the afternoon, was that I believe that the theme of discovery has been a red herring.

And I loved your analogy that you explained where that comes from. And so that would be helpful to the audience. I only knew the term.

And it came off the top of my head. I hadn't even planned to say that. It just came out, which was kind of interesting.

And what I meant by that is that discovery has been a distraction away from domination, which is the real problem. I mean, the people obtaining new knowledge or new information or knowing something that they didn't know previously certainly is not the problem in itself. If you are intending to go and locate a place you didn't know about previously, so you can set up your system of domination there over the people that are already living there, and over all of the ecological systems and so forth, that is the problem.

So that's in a nutshell, I guess, how I would open.

[Peter] (5:53 - 6:01)

Well, so let me just back up a little bit. So the host, was the host is a Catholic organizations or the native or is the Catholic?

[Steve] (6:02 - 6:34)

Well, yes, it was the Catholic organization, the National Conference of Bishops, I believe, is the way they say that. And there was a point person working with them, Wilton Littlechild, who was working with Archbishop Boland to create the list of people to be invited. And I don't know how they chose who they chose, but it was what it was.

And I was very pleased to be included in the mix.

[Peter] (6:35 - 7:00)

And so the Catholic organization of bishops was the host for the meeting. Do you have any sense or were they very clear about here's the purpose, we're calling this meeting for fill in the blank, what was the purpose of calling it? Was this billed as a follow on to the papal visit a few years back to the reconciliation?

What were there?

[Steve] (7:00 - 9:38)

Yeah, I think all of those factors were certainly in the mix. There was mention of the March 30, 2023 statement on the doctrine of discovery by the Vatican, the two departments of the Vatican, they call them dicasteries, but departments is what it means dicastery of education, and the dicastery of integral human development. And so it was, in a sense, a bit of a follow up on that.

And, but it was framed and build, if you want to call it that, as a knowledge sharing symposium. So knowledge sharing gathering, we're going to get together and share where we're coming from with regard to the theme called doctrine of discovery, and see where it goes. And I had no anticipation of anything, I just didn't know what to expect.

I said, well, I would go certainly and throw in my two cents worth and see what happens. And I think probably everybody had that some people were skeptical. But when, when things wrapped up, I think that there was a receptivity on the part of the people representing the Catholic Church and the Vatican hierarchy to there was a well, to go forward and to see what additional types of information can be brought out.

You know, in terms of practical steps or practical types of things, could you point to anything specific? No, probably you couldn't. But to me, having a commitment to actually continue the dialogue and discussion is a pretty good starting point.

Because then you have the possibility of further things developing. And I didn't really, there was not really pushback, there was, I mean, I can't believe that everyone was agreeing with the things I was saying, they probably agreed with some and disagree with other things. They didn't make a big deal of saying you're wrong or, but sometimes they would say, well, I'm not sure about that one, that business of breaking down colonization to colon and then C-O-L-O to filter out impurities in the process of mining, they kind of wince, like, that doesn't, that doesn't make sense.

You know, I can't, I can't buy that. So whatever, that's fine.

[Peter] (9:39 - 9:44)

But you didn't hesitate to put these startling ideas out there, it sounds like.

[Steve] (9:45 - 9:46)

Not at all, not at all.

[Peter] (9:47 - 11:01)

But so now just to, let me just kind of squeeze a little bit on this question of what was the stated purpose and what is the goal of the continuing discussion? What was your, is your sense that they would just like this whole discussion to go away? Why isn't it over and done with?

The Pope came, he apologized. The Vatican has made it very clear it doesn't want to do anything like revoke a bull or denounce it or anything of that sort, even though there are bulls in the past, in the centuries before that have occasionally been

overturned, I guess you might say. But so are they looking to, let's quell this discussion?

It's sidetracking our plans for further evangelization? Or am I being too cynical about that, that they really think that maybe there's a way to arrive at something that there would be a true meeting of the minds on this and that out of that meeting would come something as practical as a statement from the Vatican saying that any further use of the doctrines connected with this whole history are anathema?

[Steve] (11:02 - 11:50)

No, no, there was a statement, a brief video from Cardinal Czerny of the Dicastery of Human Development, which is something we should talk about right there, that title. But it was very receptive, very apologetic for not being able to be there. I think they know it's not going away.

They want to go deeper into it. I think they, it seems to me, and I could be mistaken, but there was a sincerity on the part of the people representing the Catholic Church to know more about what it is we're really trying to explain.

[Peter] (11:51 - 12:05)

Because you're not going away. I mean, it sounds great. You're not going away.

And they really, maybe for the, I don't know if it's the first time, but maybe they are sincere saying we really haven't got a grasp of what they're complaining about. Does that bother?

[Steve] (12:06 - 14:42)

To an extent, yeah. And that's why my presentation in particular was eye-opening for a lot of people, because there's this way in which the doctrine work or the theme of the doctrine of discovery and all that has been, it's taken on a life of its own and just gone willy-nilly wherever. And however people decide to talk about it, that's how they decide to talk about it.

There's not necessarily a rhyme or reason and the explanation of what it is will vary. But when I got up, what I did was just to describe it to folks. And I will be able to get a recording of my talk, evidently, which is good.

I'd like to put that out there. But what I did is I had our documentary movie, The Doctrine of Discovery Unmasking the Domination Code pulled up. They had a great screen, great sound system.

It took place, by the way, I hadn't mentioned that, at the Archdiocese in Edmonton. And it was where Pope Francis had stayed when he was there and visiting in Canada. So that was a significant landmark in a sense.

But they had a great sound system and a great screen. And I pulled up the section of the movie where Birgil Kills Straight, my dear friend and mentor, explains the seven laws with the image of the wounded knee massacre, many images of the wounded knee massacre on the screen. And I played that about a minute and a half, two minutes.

Then I cut it off. And then I said a brief greeting in our Lenape language and said a brief prayer in our Lenape language. And then I said that I believe that the reason everyone is gathered here on this occasion is because of the ceremonial life of my friend and mentor, Birgil Kills Straight, traditional headman and ceremonial leader of the Oglala Lakota Nation.

One of them, not the ceremonial leader, but a ceremonial leader. And the reason for that is because in 1992, in February of that year, Senator Daniel Inouye of Hawaii, he was convening hearings about the American Indian Religious Freedom Act. What do they call that?

[Peter] (14:43 - 14:44)
AIRFA.

[Steve] (14:44 - 15:01)
Yeah, but taking it to another level, not amendment, what is it? Restoration Act. American Indian Religious Freedom Restoration Act, isn't it?

[Peter] (15:02 - 15:04)
Yeah, that's after AIRFA, yeah.

[Steve] (15:04 - 15:18)
Yeah, because the American Indian Religious Freedom Act had no teeth in it. That was made evident by two Supreme Court rulings, and they wanted to add some additional dimension to the religious freedom argumentation.

[Peter] (15:18 - 15:20)
I used to say how much air is in AIRFA.

[Steve] (15:21 - 19:18)
Yeah, a fair amount. And so I was frustrated while watching, and this took place at Portland State University in February 92, as I said, and I was frustrated with that no one was mentioning the papal bulls, Johnson v. McIntosh, or anything that we're talking about these days.

And I was pretty upset, so I went to blow off some steam in the hallway, and my friend Mary Wood, who taught at the University of Oregon School of Law in Eugene, happened to be out in the hallway, and I was explaining to her why I was frustrated. And it dawned on me, I thought, you know, next year is going to be the 500-year mark since that papal bull was issued. We ought to go to the Vatican and call on the Pope to formally revoke the papal bull of May 4, 1493.

She said, that's a great idea. So the idea was born at that moment. Well, the following month, Birgil Kills Straight came to the Peace and the Planet Symposium taking place at Valley River Center in Eugene, Oregon, and it was this convening of all kinds of traditional-minded folks, ceremonial people, medicine people, different folks.

And it was sponsored by the Yupik Elder Circle and some Peace University in Costa Rica, I forget all those names right now. And so this mystery man was there with a nice leather jacket on, aviator glasses, and Stetson, and he had his arms folded and just kind of, Paige was tripped out by him because he just radiated some kind of

energy, right? And she kept, she would wonder, hmm, wonder what that guy's doing, and then I noticed him as well, but I didn't really pay that much attention.

We had a small caucus that evening, opening day, where William Comanda, Thomas Bunyak, Birgil Kills Straight, I think Slow Turtle was probably there, pretty certain. Wouldn't swear to it, but I think it might have been. And a number of these really prominent elders were there.

And so he gave a talk that evening at that statement, and it blew my mind. I was just, I was not even expecting something of that magnitude. What he was, it was so cosmic, so extraordinary, because he was explaining their understanding of the universe, the Oglala Lakota.

And so I thought, wow, this is, this man is amazing. So the following morning when I came in, he was sitting at a table by himself, and I, rather than pull a chair up in front of him, I pulled it up to one side of him. He's just kind of sitting there with his arms folded.

And so I started explaining. I introduced myself, explained what I was working on. And then his arms stretched out, and he kind of had his fingers loosely laced together.

And every so often I see this almost imperceptible little nod. And I thought, hey, this guy's actually listening to me, you know. And so that was it.

I said, well, I'm giving a keynote address later this morning. Perhaps you could come and listen. And excuse myself, unless left, he never said a word to me.

I never asked him to. And that was that. That was our introduction.

[Peter] (19:19 - 19:20)

You're telling about you and Birgil.

[Steve] (19:21 - 20:46)

Yeah. And so the later that morning when I gave my talk, it was quite extraordinary, because this had happened a prior time, the evening when I had the inspiration about the idea, but I'll explain it this way without going backwards in time, that when I got to the point of saying, and we should go to the Vatican and call upon the Pope to formally revoke the interest in the papal bull of May 4th, 1993, the whole audience erupted in applause. They stood up and started. There was this electricity that went through the whole audience.

It was quite extraordinary. I hadn't ever expected something like that, but there it was. So then we had a little tiny bit of interaction, not much.

The last day he was leaving for the airport, and he came up to me and said, you got a passport? I said, yeah. You got a phone number?

Yeah. I gave that to him. He said, we're going to Italy in November on a trip over there, and I'd like to see about bringing you along so we could begin that campaign.

And that's when he was able to do that. He flew all over the world and was just celebrated all over the world.

[Peter] (20:46 - 21:29)

So that, I do want to get back to the question of human development, but just to loop back when I said what is the, if their agreement to continuing discussions, etc., it started out from the story you just told. It started out as a very sharp-pointed effort aimed at revocation of a specific papal bull, by pulling a pin out in a doctrinal, historical sense from this whole scaffold. And I take it that that still is in some sense a goal, at least, of some of the participants who were at this recent meeting.

[Steve] (21:30 - 21:30)

No.

[Peter] (21:30 - 21:31)

No.

[Steve] (21:31 - 21:35)

No, because they don't know. See, this is where it gets really...

[Peter] (21:35 - 21:45)

You say they, but you say discovery. People are talking about discovery everywhere, but they haven't even connected the one simple dot.

[Steve] (21:46 - 22:20)

Yeah, because what happened was over time, and I think it might have been tied to a particular church resolution that where somebody changed the revocation of the papal bull, I was able to maintain that all the way up to 2010 or 11, 12, somewhere in there. And suddenly one of the big church groups, the Episcopal Church or one of them, stuck, renounced the doctrine of discovery in there. And then it was off to the races with that.

[Peter] (22:20 - 22:21)

Yeah.

[Steve] (22:21 - 25:16)

Which is a complete mis-framing. It just shows they don't even understand what the heck it's all about, right? So, we're going to say, oh, we reject that thing.

But just to get back to my little bit of a story there, Birgel and I ended up, and the reason why this is important, because most people in that room, maybe all of them, never really had heard how this whole thing got started to begin with. So, I wanted to bring that context back into focus. And we, and Birgel and I met up, well, I flew to Kyle.

I didn't say all this, but I just explained it in abbreviated form. But we went to Wounded Knee for a sunrise ceremony. And then there were talks there, and we announced that we were going to Italy and going on the speaking tour to call for the revocation of the papal bull.

That was on Columbus Day. And then we had ceremony there in Kyle. And that was the beginning of the whole campaign, in a sense, that on that occasion, to launch this very amazing spiritually grounded effort.

It was, in my view, in our view, it was always a spiritual path. We were always on a spiritual path. It wasn't about, yeah, it has to have scholarship, because you have to have the information.

But the real true nature of the work, from the time I was 16, and I got to 16, 17, I got to go into ceremony with amazing traditional elders, who, by the way, were from the Cree nation. And small boy, and Wayne Roan, and who was 28 years old when I got to go into ceremony back in 1971 or 72. And so, it was a continuation of all that.

It's really pretty amazing, right? I don't believe anybody in that room really understood how any of this had come about. So, in a sense, it was sort of like bringing things back to that corrective starting point, full circle, and saying, look, and on the ending day, I had been playing around with the resolution format, kind of clunky, but I read my resolution.

No matter what they wanted to do, I wanted our position to be very clear. Here's what's going on. Here's where we are at this time, after all these years.

And we hereby call, or ask, I put ask rather than call, just to be a bit polite, and for the Pope to revoke the papal of May 4, 14. I renewed that call, or that ask.

[Peter] (25:16 - 29:40)

It seems to me of crucial importance, because the story you just finished telling, from its inception with you meeting Burgell until the recent meeting a week or so ago, has been clearly a structural and spiritual orientation. In a sense, its ground is a spiritual ground. And I want to just say at this point that you know how much research we've done, people who've listened to us, you know how we've researched for decades around this, and there's all this information, but the information by itself does not seem to have any effect if there's no spiritual grounding to the person who's receiving that information.

So, I want to emphasize the spiritual foundation, but I also want to emphasize the structural aim, let's say, or presentation. And it seems to me, you hinted at this just moments ago, that there's a tremendous amount of rhetoric around something called discovery, or doctrinal discovery. And it's hard to, if you have anything to do with Indian country, it's hard to avoid running into people talking about, oh, we've got to deal with the doctrinal discovery.

But it's sort of like froth, you know, on a bowl of soup or something, that there's a very specific structural, doctrinal, historical framework to all of this, and that's mostly ignored, not understood. And I think also the spiritual basis is not really understood, because if you understand the spiritual basis, then you cannot take the position that, oh, this is a problem for Indians, because we have said it and shown over and over again, the domination that's inherent in that notion of discovery doctrine, that domination was already in existence for over a thousand years in Europe before those people even knew there was a place called, you know, the Western Hemisphere. So, if we're talking about, oh, this doctrine needs to be overturned,

what we're really saying, if we have a spiritual grounding, and we understand the long history, the thousands of years history, then we're talking about a re-understanding of what life on Earth is for human beings in relation to all the other beings in the world. And it's not a niche issue.

It's not relegated to some specific subgroup of America, quote-unquote. It's not even just something that happened in 1823 with a specific Supreme Court decision. It's bigger, includes all of that, but it's bigger, much more depth-grounded and much more structurally focused.

So, that's just me kind of doing a little riff on what you're saying. And so, the continuation of the discussion, it seems to me, there still is an absence of understanding that what we're continuing the discussion toward is a specific proposal here. It's not just a discussion.

It reminds me a little bit, we've said we should talk about this, it reminds me of the so-called Permanent Forum for Indigenous Issues at the United Nations. They don't even say indigenous peoples anymore, it's issues, okay? So, some abstract category of verbiage.

And there's a permanent forum, which means, what is a forum? It's a place to talk. So, they've just agreed to talk forever about issues.

No endpoint, no goal. It's not like negotiations going on to some specific point. And it sounds like however useful this session was, and however it's indeed significant that you got a chance to tell them where this all began, and that you haven't given up this effort and this quest in all the intervening years, that you're still in your resolution calling for the very same thing you called for how many decades ago when you and Birgil made that trip.

I think that is really the most significant thing to say about this whole gathering. So, that's just me listening to you and responding to how I hear what you're saying. And if there's, if I'm off the wall on it, or off the, say so.

[Steve] (29:40 - 34:14)

It's your perception, the way you're explaining what's occurring to you, as you hear this account of what took place, as best I recall it. What was really interesting about that inspiration in the hallway at Portland State University, outside the auditorium there, was the kind of aha moment, and how profound that was. And I said, oh my gosh, this is amazing.

This is, what a concept. And I wasn't thinking, oh, I'm, you know, whatever, because I, it just was, it's like I just noticed something. Wow, what a great insight as far as a way to approach this whole matter, and to begin to educate folks.

So, when I went back to the, that evening, there was a powwow that evening, and I decided to go for a walk. And Portland State University is a gorgeous campus with all massive evergreen trees, a whole, what do they call it, kind of a parkway. And this huge swath of trees, and massive trees, and the wind was blowing.

And it was February, but it was unusually warm that evening. And the wind in the, all in the branches, I just, there was this spiritual electricity. I had the sense of this deep, deep spiritual connection with something.

And I guess with just the profound nature of what had occurred to me. So, I was out there for a long time, and doing some, you know, some spiritually grounding, spending time out there with all that. And so, when I went back to the powwow, which was kind of jarring, like all the bright lights, and dancing, and everything.

Powwow was a great, great event. But, you know, from that spiritual, amazing solitude to that was kind of much. And so, a friend said, hey, I had told him earlier about my idea.

He said, Matthew Fox, the Catholic theologian, is giving a talk right down the street at the Methodist church, I think it was. You ought to go down there and ask, and tell him about your idea. I said, man, that's great.

I think I'll do that. So, I walked down there, and it was this huge stone church. And when I walked in, it was packed.

The balcony, the whole place completely packed. And it was in a Q&A session. And I stood there with my back against a pillar.

And he was finishing up a question, responding to a question. And I realized, if I don't get very bold at this moment, nothing will happen. I will never have an opportunity.

And I timed it perfectly. As soon as he ended that, I walked forward, and I said, Mr. Fox, and I had my arm up. And I walked right out there on the floor.

And I gave the most concise summary imaginable about the connection between the papal bull of 1493, the John Cabot charter, the Johnson versus McIntosh ruling, the whole thing. And then I said, next year will be the 500th year since the papal bull was issued. Do you think that Pope John Paul II would formally revoke the papal bull of May 4th, 1493?

And the most amazing thing happened. The entire place went nuts with applause. This electricity just went through the whole building.

And this amazing electricity and applause. And it was a moment. And he said, well, I don't know if he would, but I certainly think he should.

And furthermore, I think he should take all that gold out of St. Peter's Cathedral and give it back to the Indians they stole it from.

[Peter] (34:17 - 35:26)

Well, these are important moments somehow. I mean, I think the combination of the spiritual awareness and groundedness, and then the moments of interaction, like you described, it's that combination that's really crucial. I want to back up.

You talked about one of the dicasteries, and you said it's really just the department at the Vatican is called- Integral Human Development. Integral Human. Just to be straight out frank, it sounds like gobbledygook to me.

I don't know integral human development. I mean, I can guess what it's supposed to mean. It's an apple pie in motherhood.

It's a wonderful thing. We should all be in favor of integral human development. At the end of the day, what does it actually mean?

And so, again, maybe I'm just being too provocative, expecting something that's not going to happen. But so a whole Vatican department around integral human development, what is that? Anybody try to say what are they actually here for?

What's that all about? Or do you have any thoughts? Like, what does that phrase mean?

[Steve] (35:26 - 36:22)

Well, I do. I didn't take the opportunity, and I wish I had now that you're mentioning it, to actually ask for clarification of that key point. That would have been sensible.

Well, my understanding of it at this point, from my point of view, is explained on the basis of a California Supreme Court ruling from 1930 called City of San Diego versus Cuyamaca Water Company. And in that ruling, the court segues a bit to history and the church and the mission system that was being set up in the late 17th century. And they claim that the native population, as they put it, was living in a state of barbarism.

[Peter] (36:23 - 36:24)

The court said this?

[Steve] (36:24 - 40:08)

Yes. So the state of barbarism, when you look at that, you can understand that they are either only partially human or not human at all. And in order to make them human, you have to involve yourself in a human development project.

So, there are steps to the process whereby they are going to become fully human or human, however they might frame that. And the very first part of it involves baptism. They've already baptized the land because they came ashore in Junipero Serra and Gaspar de Portola, I believe it was, that was there at that time.

And they engaged in the ceremony of possession and did some kind of ritualistic act. And Dr. Luis Rivera Pagan, in our documentary movie, explains that when they did those things, they were baptizing the land. And so, they also baptized the people, then they give them a different name, a Christian name.

And once they have done that, that's the starting point for the human development. Because they're taking them on a transition from barbarism to a civilized and Christian life. But the beginning part is not the baptism.

It is, but it involves another dimension of that, which is to deprive them of their free and independent existence. Without depriving them of their free and independent

existence, they cannot be involved in the human development enterprise. And that's the point that everyone has missed.

That when we learn these words, just generally, civilization, and state, and sovereignty, and all these, you know, all the vocabulary, we never talk about the original free existence of the people. I was paying close attention to how everyone was framing things and said, well, when they came and took the land, or they claim and took possession of the land. So, what does that have to do with the free existence of the people?

It's not being mentioned. It's not even in the awareness. It's not a focus at all.

And so, that's where I think we need to modify our approach, and we have been doing that. And make that contrast, that stark contrast, between the original free existence and their assumption of a right of domination coming ashore and involving themselves and all that. That we have to make that contrast between that assertion of a right of domination and the free existence, the central focus.

What happens is attention is placed on, oh, they're evangelizing, they're spreading the good news, they're bringing the Bible, they're doing all these. So, every single one of those descriptions in the mind of the audience is a positive. Oh, yeah.

And so, how does the Supreme Court of California handle that? They said they were bringing the blessings and fruits of civilization and Christianity to the native population, when in fact, they were bringing domination. So, it's the blessings and fruits of domination.

That's the contradiction that never gets brought out into the open, because nobody has gone this deep into all of the nuance and detail to be able to get to this point of clarity.

[Peter] (40:09 - 40:33)

Wow. So, is it too far of a leap? What I'm thinking is that that understanding, that logic, would lead us to say that every current effort to say, oh, Indians are equal in the constitutional structure of the United States, is actually just a repetition of the same process.

[Steve] (40:34 - 40:58)

Same agenda. Yep. Same process, same agenda.

We're all one. We're all one is Catholicism, universalism. Catholic means universal.

The universal truth, the universal whatever. And so, one verse, uni-verse, one chapter, one verse. It's the playbook.

[Peter] (40:58 - 41:50)

Yeah. Well, I couldn't resist quickly looking at the OED here on integral, and it comes from their Latin root for integer, which means intact, entire, and in the Italian, entire, consisting of entire-ness. Okay.

So, if we come back to integral human development, I mean, it says, okay, we're developing the entire human. Okay. I'm not sure exactly what are we supposed to do with that?

Does that mean if you just gave somebody weights, and they built their body up, okay, they're developing their body, but they didn't develop their whole self. They didn't develop their mind or whatever. Is that one of the things that they want to have all the humans be developed?

But then we got to look at development. What do we mean by development? Because that certainly sounds an awful lot like what you just described.

[Steve] (41:50 - 43:37)

I'll give you the answer. I'll give you the answer. Here's how you do that.

You strip them of their language, their culture, their ceremonial traditions, their free way of life, anything to do with their identity in that horrible, barbarous, heathen, pagan, savage, infidel world has to be done away with for integral human development to occur. Now, that's the old version. So, when they came, the Franciscans and the Dominicans came together in 1775, wherever the heck it was, they entered into an agreement where they talked about being occupied, meaning preoccupied, having their attention upon the spiritual conquest of old and new California, by which they meant way down south where they had already been colonizing, and then up north, up here in quote-unquote Southern California. So, but spiritual conquest, what is that? So, that's spiritual domination, but they'll say a spiritual victory.

So, that's where the whole issue of language and subtlety of language from their viewpoint and our viewpoint is so crucial in this effort, because they're only looking at it from their vantage point. And now what they do is they cast aside all the old terminology, and they bring it up to current times. Now we're the very reasonable people that are listening to you and involved and engaged, but these are rhetorical strategies.

They're approaches to persuasion. Yeah. And that's a part of the integral human development.

[Peter] (43:38 - 43:48)

Yeah. I mean, it reminds me, isn't it, the Inquisition, what used to be called the Office for the Inquisition, got renamed Office for the, what, Congregation of the Faith?

[Steve] (43:48 - 43:50)

Of the Doctrine of Faith. Yeah.

[Peter] (43:50 - 45:31)

So, yeah, changed their names. I think I mentioned once before, this is a trivial, well, it isn't trivial, which compared to what you're describing here, but the state of Massachusetts some years ago decided that prisons was a bad thing, so they abolished prisons. Well, what did they do?

They instituted houses of correction. Of course, the buildings and the bars and the gates and the bells and everything else stayed exactly the same, but a new

nameplate was put onto it. And there are no more prisoners either, because there's no more prisoner, so there are just residents, residents in this house of correction.

I mean, the men that I met with during that period of time, they called it Native Awareness Circle, Spiritual Awareness Circle. They sort of joked about, sort of at the end of the meeting, one of them said, well, I'm going to go back to my room now. We don't have cells anymore.

I mean, it looks exactly the same, the bars are the same, that toilet bowl to the wall, that's all the same, but it's a room now. So I'm thinking, and so much of what is attached to the Doctrine of Discovery rhetoric is at that level, where changing some words or let's use some different language, I don't hear anybody, in fact, people get lost in this. They talk about land back without really understanding that what that means in a technical legal sense is still U.S. claim of ownership, for example, but you have people waving that flag and saying that somehow that's the opposite of Discovery Doctrine, when in fact, it's just the same thing with new clothes on.

[Steve] (45:34 - 46:24)

Well, there's a way in which a lot of people have presumed that they are fully equipped to engage in this type of work, quote-unquote, because they have a brain, they have the ability to make sounds and create language, they have the ability to write and do all these things, so that in and of itself is enough that qualifies you to hold forth on something you may not really understand. You might not have fully committed to memory exactly what that Doctrine of Discovery is, but then there's this funny thing in English where, oh yeah, I know all about that, meaning I had heard all about it, but instead of saying I heard all about it, then you say I know all about it. That's just, that's the sloppiness of English at times.

[Peter] (46:24 - 47:01)

Yeah, well, and it's such a common, my colleague Ron Pipkin in legal studies years ago just made us all laugh during the first week when you're advising new students and so on and so forth, and he's talking about what their background is, and they're coming into this legal studies study, and one of the students said, well, I had history, and Ron burst out, oh, he said, so you're not in danger, you're not going to get it again because you already had it.

It's like it was a sickness and now you're immune to it, so you're immune to history, and that's, yeah, so they, and so there's a superficial way,

[Steve] (47:01 - 48:35)

it's the difference between revoking a papal document or having the pope do that as a call or an ask and renouncing a doctrine or dismantling a doctrine, so the people are not hyper-conscious of the metaphors that they use, so if I have an old junk car out back and I can take my, all my tools out there and start dismantling the car because it has screws and nuts and bolts and washers and different things that I need to tear apart, you know, I can dismantle it, but how do you do that with ideas?

They're not physical, so it's the application of the analogy of something mechanical that you would take apart and disassemble, and you're applying that to ideas without ever asking yourself, well, how, in what way, you know, in what respect? Richard

Harvey Brown says that's a great way to inquire into a metaphorical framing. In what respect is it like this, or as if it were like this, as if it were this particular thing?

So, even the idea of doctrine, every single one of the words needs intensive effort to clarify in what context and in what sense. Most people don't engage in all that type of effort, too much of a pain. It's easy just to go around talking about doctrine of discovery.

[Peter] (48:37 - 50:11)

Yes, it is, because it makes you feel good, but it's kind of, it's, the situation is so far and meshed in daily life that it seems like there's either a, there's no real place to get a toehold. How does this relate to daily life for me, for all humans, or for the planet, or any of that? That's a stretch too far.

Let's just talk, let's leave it simple, like discovery, the Indians. That's one thing. The other one is that the structure, the domination processes and structures are so woven into what's considered regular, ordinary daily life.

So, there are millions of people that they live in a box, they get into a box with wheels, they go to another box, they spend hours there, and then they get into the box and wheel, they go back to the first box, and that's life. And whether they're happy about it or depressed about it, or whether they don't think about it, how are they prepared to start, you know, looking at, dealing with, thinking about the underpinnings of that whole structure that they're in? Why am I in this situation?

I was in the grocery store yesterday, and one of the staff members was talking to another one, and I'm familiar with both of them, so I just kind of leaned in, and one of them was saying, so, who invented this reality? Everything is just performative, and I just laughed, I said, that's a great question, and then I went on my way to get some cheese or whatever I was.

[Steve] (50:11 - 51:38)

That's funny. Well, that's another key point, because it is about reality. And what is perceived, but what is reality?

I mean, so we say, oh, yeah, we're going to change reality. Well, how do you do that? I mean, we're on a mass scale, so if you want to bring the whole world economy to a screeching halt because you have some agenda, there are some people that seem to have the ability to do that, but that's a pretty tall order.

For the average everyday person, they can't do that, and so we can reflect upon the reality that we're experiencing, but, and we might even be able to shift our own reality to a little bit of extent, but these, we're talking about how did this global reality get created and maintained over time with all these horrific patterns that have occurred against our nations and peoples, against our original free existence, and then look at the wreckage afterwards, and let's say, let's just enter into, which is a whole other conversation we'll have to have, how do we enter into reconciliation? Wait a minute, we never had a positive relationship. You've created all this horrendous, or your institution has created all this tremendous wreckage in its wake, and then let's, now let's get together and reconcile, so the whole thing is a bit loony.

[Peter] (51:38 - 53:40)

Yeah, yeah, and I mean, we're getting near the top of the hour, but I want to add two things to what you're saying. One is that why it's so crucial that people don't make the mistake that all we're talking about is American Indians. That's the prime example we're using that sheds light on everything, thousands of years of history, all around the planet, but it sheds light on all life today, and so there are too many opportunities missed for people to see a bigger picture, so let's say, oh, it's just, for example, in the day when it was just the early days of women's, oh, it's women, if the position of women were changed, that's really what's crucial here, and or pick out some other, you know, specific category, so we, that's why we emphasize again and again that original free existence is not something that only one, certain numbers of people on one continent had.

We're talking about human life in general, and the way in which domination has been structured over thousands of years, that's one key thing that I think differentiates what we're talking about from something that somebody might say, oh, well, they're just in a protest group. What's their sign say, you know? We're engaging in something more than that, so when you say what is reality, I mean, how many people take the opportunity if you're going to talk about, let's just say, men and women, and we're certainly, things are far more complicated than that in terms of the rhetoric, but what does it mean to be human?

Well, you touched on that before. Oh, how many times do people go down that thing? You mean the whole category of being human is itself worth looking at here, not just particular sexes within this category human, and one other, the other piece that laps over is so-called rights of nature, like there's a famous book that was written back in the center, Trees Have Rights.

Well, it's been bothering me for how many decades now, trees have, I mean, trees are.

[Steve] (53:40 - 53:42)

Well, do trees have standing?

[Peter] (53:42 - 54:43)

Yeah, trees have standing, that's what it was, and so, and standing in a legal sense, you know, can a tree bring a lawsuit, okay? You say, well, a tree is existing at such a fundamental level that it's deeper than law itself, so we're imagining how do we squeeze nature, the reality of nature into something called rights of nature, like how do we, because rights is a concept of state, the state system, how do we squeeze reality inside the box called the state, and you and I are, I mean, the more we talk about it, I think the clearer we get, and I hope we're getting, being able to say it clearly, is that the project is to stand outside that whole box, not to figure out how to squeeze, oh, if we could just get Indians into the constitutional structure, there are some very well-known legal scholars that that's their goal, get Indians into the constitutional structure so they have, quote, civil rights. That has nothing to do with original free existence.

[Steve] (54:44 - 54:44)

Yeah.

[Peter] (54:44 - 55:33)

How do we, it's the opposite of it, so anyway, I'm going to leave it at that for now, but I feel like there's so much that comes out of what you described as the discussions that you were in, the fact that those discussions are still happening, the fact that the discussions are still kind of trying to slide away from the sharp point that you are making, and the fact that that sharp point is built on a spiritual and scholarly foundation dating back some decades, all of that is still in play, and that's what we're working with, and that's what we're working in. I guess we can leave it there. All right, Steve, I really appreciate you taking the time to subject yourself to me asking questions like I'm an interviewer.

[Steve] (55:33 - 55:43)

It's a treat, it's a treat, because I usually don't explain that. My daughter Shawna always says, Dad, you need to explain the story behind the story of the doctrine.

[Peter] (55:43 - 55:44)

Yeah, yeah.

[Steve] (55:44 - 55:45)

That's what we're doing.

[Peter] (55:46 - 55:49)

Yeah. All right, Steve, thank you very much. We'll be in touch.